F♯ Minor

Scale Practice Worksheet · 3 sharps (F♯, C♯, G♯) · Relative minor of A major · 4 octaves

Warming up with Hanon

F♯ minor is a rather unintuitive key. To get familiar with the scale before jumping into the main exercises, play Hanon No. 1 transposed into F♯ harmonic minor. Play in two octaves, slowly.

Hanon No. 1 uses a repeating five-finger pattern: skip a scale degree, then four notes up, three notes back down — landing one step higher each time. In F♯ harmonic minor the first groups are:

F♯ A B C♯ D C♯ B A

G♯ B C♯ D E♯ D C♯ B

A C♯ D E♯ F♯ E♯ D C♯ …

Continue ascending through two octaves, then reverse the pattern back down. The E♯ (raised 7th) is the note that gives harmonic minor its character — listen for it as you play through.

SCALES

01 Scale — Harmonic & Melodic Minor

Play F♯ minor across 4 octaves in both forms.

Harmonic minor raises the 7th degree: E becomes E♯.

Melodic minor raises both the 6th and 7th degrees ascending — D becomes D♯, E becomes E♯. Descending, remove all added sharps and play as natural minor.

Play parallel motion (both hands same direction), then add contrary motion.

02 Scale in Tenths — Harmonic Minor

Play F♯ harmonic minor in tenths (octave + third between hands).

Play ascending and descending, then add contrary motion.

> TIP
> If you are not familiar with the scale, play it in two octaves first.

03 Scale in Tenths — Melodic Minor

Play F♯ melodic minor in tenths.

Ascending: D♯ and E♯. Descending: remove all sharps, descend as natural minor.

04 Scale in Sixths — Melodic Minor

Play F♯ melodic minor in the interval of sixths.

TIP
The 4th finger in the right hand requires attention. If the scale feels difficult, slow down and take your time.

ARPEGGIOS & CHORDS — TONIC

05 Four-Note Chords

Play the tonic chord as solid four-note chords to get familiar with the chord structure and distances before moving to arpeggios.

TECHNIQUE
The entire arm should be very free at all three joints — wrist, elbow, shoulder. Imagine the hand connecting all the way to the back — always feel that connection. Strong fingers, relaxed hand, flexible wrist.

06 Long Arpeggios

Extended arpeggios starting from F♯ — a black key. Root position, 1st inversion, 2nd inversion. Start with the 2nd finger and connect all notes. Play as legato as possible.

TECHNIQUE
The dangerous spot is the position change after the thumb. Move very quickly to the 4th finger, then prepare the next position immediately — don't get stuck in the previous hand shape. Practice the transition separately if needed.

TIP
1st inversion is much easier because it starts from a white key. 2nd inversion is more difficult.

SIX-CHORD ARPEGGIOS

07 Long Six-Chord Arpeggios

Play extended arpeggios through a cycle of six chords in sequence. The roman numeral pattern is **I – i – VI – ♯vi – IV – iv**.

For F♯ minor:

1) **F♯ major — I** (tonic major, root position)

2) **F♯ minor — i** (tonic minor, root position)

3) **D major — VI** (1st inversion)

4) **D♯ minor — ♯vi** (1st inversion)

5) **B major — IV** (2nd inversion)

6) **B minor — iv** (2nd inversion)

Play each chord as a long arpeggio across the keyboard before moving to the next.

08 Eleven Long Chords

Play extended arpeggios through a cycle of eleven chords in sequence, starting from F♯ — a black key. Play each chord as a long arpeggio across the keyboard, then move immediately to the next without stopping.

The eleven-chord cycle for F♯ minor:

Tonic:

1) **F♯ major** — root position

2) **F♯ minor** — root position

3) **F♯ major** — 1st inversion

4) **F♯ minor** — 1st inversion

5) **F♯ major** — 2nd inversion

6) **F♯ minor** — 2nd inversion

Dominant:

7) **C♯7** — root position

8) **C♯7** — 1st inversion

9) **C♯7** — 2nd inversion

10) **C♯7** — 3rd inversion

Diminished:

11) **E♯ dim** — 4-note chord (vii°)

TIP
The fingering from a black key is uncomfortable. Choose one fingering position and stick to it — the secret is to play them fast. More comfortable fingerings exist for individual chords (e.g. using 3 instead of 4 in the right hand), but the point is playing all eleven chords in a row without stopping. The full cycle is long — that is the point. These build stamina.

TIP
If you are trying this for the first time, start learning them even if they feel difficult. The discomfort and the length of the cycle are the point. This is one of the best exercises from scales practice. Apply the rhythmic variation from the Variations section below.

VARIATIONS

Contrary Motion

Any scale or arpeggio exercise can be played in contrary motion — one hand ascending while the other descends simultaneously. This is harder than parallel motion and excellent brain training.

Accent & Rhythmic Variations

Apply to any scale or arpeggio exercise, or to the eleven long chords (Exercise 08):

a Prolong the 3rd note of each group and accent it.

GENERAL PRACTICE PRINCIPLES

- Always warm up slowly — even scales can be dangerous for your hands if you start too fast with cold muscles
- When you hit a technical problem, start close to it and solve it on the spot — don't go back to the beginning
- Practicing is about making mistakes — detecting and solving problems is the goal, not being perfect